

Accessibility (WCAG) Audit Checklist

WCAG 2.2 AA Essentials

Accessibility is a legal requirement in many markets and a usability win in all of them. This checklist focuses on the failures that appear most often in audits and are cheapest to fix.

What's inside

- Colour contrast ratios and how to test them
- Keyboard navigation and focus order
- Form labelling and error messaging
- Alt text decision tree
- Screen reader landmarks and headings

Perceivable

- 01 4.5:1 contrast for body text, 3:1 for large text and UI
- 02 Every meaningful image has descriptive alt text
- 03 Decorative images use empty alt="" so they are skipped
- 04 Never use colour alone to convey meaning

Operable

- 01 Every interactive element is reachable by keyboard alone
- 02 Focus indicators are visible and never removed by CSS
- 03 Focus order follows visual order logically
- 04 Provide a skip-to-content link before the navigation

Understandable

- 01 Every input has a programmatically associated label
- 02 Errors are described in text, not just colour
- 03 Navigation is consistent across pages
- 04 Set the page language on the html element

Robust

- 01 Use semantic HTML before reaching for ARIA
- 02 One h1 per page with a logical heading hierarchy
- 03 Landmarks: header, nav, main, footer on every page
- 04 Test with an actual screen reader, not only automated tools

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